Worksheet 1: The Prompt Lab

From vague instructions to precision engineering

Building AI Agents Workshop | SRM AP x Kalvium | November 2026

You wouldn't hand a new employee a task with zero instructions and expect a perfect result. Yet that's what most people do with AI. This worksheet makes you confront the gap between what you THINK you asked and what the AI actually HEARD.

A. Your first attempt (before you know better)

Think of a real task you'd want AI to help with. Not a toy example -- something you'd actually use. Write your first-instinct prompt below. Don't overthink it. Write what you'd naturally type into ChatGPT.

Examples: summarize a chapter, write an email, explain a concept, debug code, plan a study schedule

My task (what I actually need done):

My V1 prompt (write it exactly as you'd type it):

B. Dissect your own prompt

Now tear your own prompt apart. Be brutally honest.

- [ ] Did you specify WHO the AI should act as? (e.g., 'You are a senior recruiter' vs. nothing)
- [ ] Did you specify the FORMAT you want? (bullet points, paragraph, table, code)
- [ ] Did you specify the LENGTH? (one sentence, 200 words, 3 paragraphs)
- [ ] Did you specify the AUDIENCE? (5-year-old, college student, expert)
- [ ]

Did you give CONTEXT about yourself or the situation?

- [ ] Did you specify what to AVOID? (jargon, fluff, assumptions)
- [ ] Did you give an EXAMPLE of what good output looks like?

Count your checks: _____ / 7

Most people check 0-2 on their first prompt. That's not failure -- it's a starting point.

C. The rewrite

Using what you just learned, rewrite your prompt. Include at least 4 of the 7 elements above. This is V2.

My V2 prompt:

D. Run both versions

Run V1 and V2 through the AI (use Demo 1 on the workshop app, or any LLM). Paste or summarize the outputs.

V1 output (first 3-4 lines or key points):

V2 output (first 3-4 lines or key points):

E. Compare and reflect

What specific difference do you see between V1 and V2 output?

Which of the 7 elements made the biggest difference? Why?

What would V3 look like -- what would you change next?

F. The temperature experiment

Run your V2 prompt at temperature=0.1 (predictable) and temperature=0.9 (creative). Compare.

Output at temperature=0.1 (key differences):

Output at temperature=0.9 (key differences):

Which temperature is better for YOUR task? Why?

G. Reflection: what did you learn about communication?

This isn't just about AI. Prompt engineering is really about clear communication. Being specific, providing context, defining format, giving examples -- these skills work with humans too.

One thing I'll do differently when giving instructions (to AI or humans) from now on:

The hardest part of writing a good prompt was: